

**AJAX****What is AJAX?**

AJAX stands for Asynchronous JavaScript and XML. It is a Web development technique for interactive Web applications—a method that defines how Web pages interact with the server and the client.

When was it developed?

The technique was used way back in 2000, when JavaScript Remote Scripting was first used. But back then, it was purely based on JavaScript.

Why is AJAX gaining in popularity?

The concept is very simple, and the programmer doesn't have to learn a new language. With Ajax, you can create richer, more dynamic Web application user interfaces that approach the immediacy and usability of native desktop applications.

How is AJAX better than just HTML?

AJAX makes Web pages more user-friendly—the entire HTML page doesn't need to refresh each time a change is made. It allows for updating, deleting, and fetching of small queries without the entire page needing to be submitted. This makes the page more interactive, and quicker. AJAX also reduces interaction with the server.

Where will AJAX be used?

AJAX will be used in almost all Web pages that need to be more interactive, and to reduce response time.

Who has used AJAX?

The technique has been extensively used by Google in their applications such as Gmail.

Another example is portal applications, which bring up information from multiple sources and provide application services to the portlets that comprise the portal Web application. To the user, the portlet applications are similar to windowed applications on a desktop. Most portals are in a scenario where an action in one windowed application causes content in all other applications to be refreshed! Web developers employ AJAX-style programming to combat this behaviour.

Homeland Security to create a list of emerging threats for 2006. Their report said four main emerging threats are likely to grow: hackers using instant messaging to spread viruses and worms; phishing becoming more widespread; virus attacks on cell phones and PDAs; and hackers targeting online brokerage accounts.

PAY TO PATCH

\$49.95 To Protect Windows!

A new security service from Microsoft will charge users \$49.95 (Rs 2,300) per year to protect Windows better from spyware, viruses and such. The subscription service is called Windows OneCare Live, and Microsoft plans to release it in early June. The service will compete with security products by traditional Microsoft partners, including Symantec and McAfee.

OneCare is already available for free in test form, and promises to provide regular tune-ups to help keep computers running smoothly. It also offers users a way to back up and restore data. The

system will automatically update with the latest protections and occasionally add new features. Sounds to us like a piece of software for people who have no clue about what's going on in their computers.

It is questionable whether Microsoft would have any more luck than its competitors in persuading people to safeguard their systems. Analyst Ted Schadler with Forrester Research said, "The big opportunity is to get to people who don't have any security," he said, but "Microsoft doesn't have any better way to get to those people than anybody else."

What strikes us most about all this is that apart from the frills such as the tune-ups, an operating system is supposed to be complete. It is supposed to have inbuilt security, but naturally, threats change, and that's what patches are for, but aren't the patches free? Why the \$49.95? Let's spell it out: your computer runs Windows. There are threats to Windows because of all the security holes in it. If Windows didn't have these many security holes, there wouldn't be so many threats. Therefore, in our opinion, the manufacturer

of Windows should protect it for free.

It's a smart product idea, we must admit—the "one-Windows-companion-package" concept.

AIMED AT COLLABORATION

MS Office 2007 Due This Year

What was supposed to be called Microsoft Office 12 has been rechristened Microsoft Office 2007. Microsoft will bundle a host of additional products along with the next version of Office. These will include specialised tools to help employees work together across continents.

Microsoft is also adding a new, higher-end version of the suite aimed at businesses that need sophisticated ways to collaborate. In addition, Microsoft will release some new and updated desktop and server software aimed at helping businesses with specialised tasks such as managing forms.

In Office 2007, Microsoft has totally revamped the user interface—only the tools relevant for the current job would be highlighted. Running across the top of the screen is something called the Ribbon, which replaces the traditional menus and toolbars with a set of graphical command tabs that correspond to the task at hand. Essentially, the Ribbon highlights oft-used features in a context-sensitive way.

Office 2007 will support XML-based document types. It will also be based on the fast search technology of Vista, which will enable document search from within Office applications.

The various versions of the suite, due out late this year, will cost about the same as Office 2003. ■

